

High school students teach environmental awareness during Earth Day celebrations

Story and photo by
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When Lejeune High School students in third and fifth period ecology class took on the responsibility of teaching environmental issues to other students, they didn't know what to expect.

After six months of research and planning, the students held their own Earth Day at the school Friday.

"The day was designed to give students an awareness of what it going on with our environment and what they could do to help," said ecology teacher Pam Lindner.

"A lot of times we abuse things like electricity and we don't even know why we should conserve."

The students began the project by researching environmental books and pam-

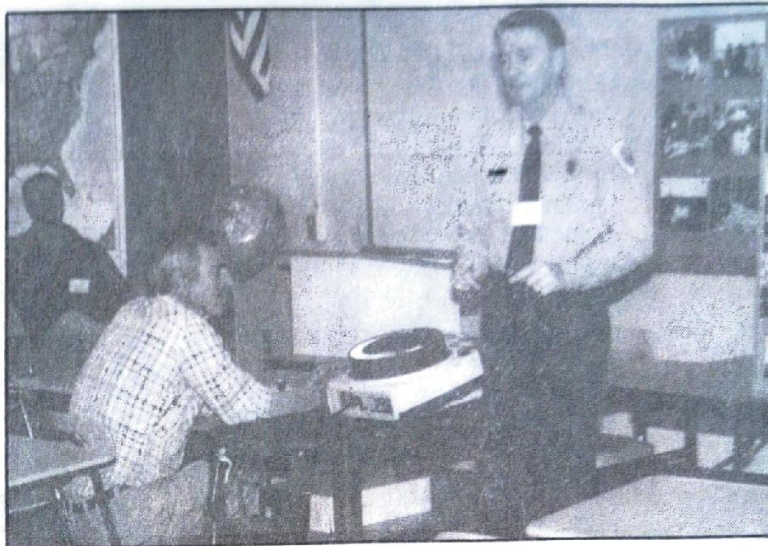
phlets. Then they wrote to several different organizations asking them to speak at the school.

"At first, we didn't think we'd get any responses so we prepared to give all the classes ourselves," said Josh Rivera-Class, fifth period student.

"Then after a little while, the responses just started pouring in."

More than 25 organizations volunteered to speak at the school, some traveling from as far as Charlotte.

During the day-long event, representatives from such organizations as Carolina Power and Light, North Carolina Coastal Federation and Alternative Energy Corporation, talked to students about their role in protecting our environment.



Guest speakers came to Lejeune High School on Earth Day and shared with students how they can become more environmentally conscious.

"This was the most attentive I've seen my students in a long time" said teacher assistant Eleanor Washington.

Catching the attention of most of the students was

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Deborah Sue Griffin from the Carolina Raptor Center. Griffin brought with her a bald eagle, red-tailed hawk and a screeching owl and explained to the students how these birds were facing extinction because of mistreatment.

"I never realized how cruel some people can be to these birds," said Fernando Delgado, also in the fifth period class.

After listening to all the speakers, most students agreed that the easiest thing an individual can do to save the environment is recycle.

"Just by picking up an aluminum can or taking plastic to the recycling center, an individual can make a lot of difference," said student Sabrina Prince.

"By having an Earth Day at Lejeune High School, we wanted the students to stop and think. I think we accomplished that."



Jeff Sizeman

Debra Sue Griffin shows high school students a red-tailed hawk, now on the verge of extinction.